

heritage TAJ MAHAL

NO WELCOME:
The most visited
monument in India



NOT SO WONDERFUL

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Even as the nation celebrates the Taj Mahal's inclusion in a list of the seven wonders of the world, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has managed to scupper an ambitious conservation project funded by the Tata Group's Indian Hotels Company Limited (IHCL). The Rs 14-crore project under the National Culture Fund (NCF) was kickstarted when the Group's chairman, Ratan Tata, signed an MOU with Ananth Kumar, the then minister for culture, in 2001. The first part of the plan, to create two visitors' centres at the Taj Mahal, was well underway when the ASI chose to inform the Supreme Court about it as a matter of "precaution" because it involved opening up a boundary wall—a wall that was built in 1922 and was not part of the original 1631 construction. The result: work on the visitors' centre on the eastern gate has

India votes to make the Taj Mahal one of the seven wonders of the world, but a Rs 14-crore conservation initiative, funded by the Tata Group, is allowed to stall

now been stalled for over two years; that on the western gate has not even begun, and IHCL has written to ASI that it cannot continue with the project despite having invested Rs 2 crore of money and the time of some of the world's finest conservationists (from Bernard Feilden to Milo Beach) in the project. So much so that even Minister for Tourism and Culture Ambika Soni says, "In all deference to the Supreme Court, I wish it would make a pronouncement on this so that the work can begin again."

The irony is that when the UNESCO

World Heritage Convention committee met in Christchurch, New Zealand, last month, it commended the Taj Mahal Conservation Collaborative (TMCC) project for having greatly helped in generating awareness on the Taj Mahal. A project that Shirin Batliwala, vice-president, food and beverage, IHCL, now says "cannot carry on". Former director-general, ASI, Babu Rajeev, who is now a consultant to the Ministry of Culture, says ASI "erred on the side of caution" by taking the issue to the Supreme Court. ASI Agra Circle Superintendent D. Dayalan

10,000 visit the Taj Mahal every day

Rs 50 lakh is spent by ASI on Taj every year